

CHAPTER SIX

THE SECRETS OF TIME: ASTROLOGY AND SACRED HISTORY

Not only the revelatory potential of experiential knowledge and the ontological dimensions of words belonged to the shared passions of medieval and early modern intellectuals; the search for the secret meaning of time and history is another example of discursive transfers. Until the late seventeenth century, it was astrology that served as the major disciplinary tool to unlock the hidden dimensions of past, present, and future. What is more, astrology is an important link between religious traditions on the one hand, and between cultural systems on the other. In fact, medieval and early modern astrology is much more closely related to mathematics, medicine, and philosophy of nature, than to what scholars have vaguely addressed as ‘occult sciences.’¹ In this chapter I will first give an overview of medieval Muslim astrology before I will turn to the Christian astrology of the same period, which can be described as an adaptation of Muslim traditions of knowledge, but which also reveals its own transmission and reworking of ancient doctrines leading to astonishing results already in the ninth century.²

Critical Response to Ancient Traditions: Medieval Arabic Astrology

From the beginning, most Muslim rulers were open to science and philosophy. This led to a very fruitful transmission of ancient knowledge. What is more, the pre-Islamic traditions of Mesopotamia and Persia still had a considerable influence, which is revealed by the

¹ On the status of astrology in these historical contexts see Newman & Grafton, “Introduction.” On the notion of ‘occult sciences’ see also chapter 7 below.

² For a more detailed description of medieval astrology, see particularly Boudet, *Entre science et nigromance*; see also Tester, *History of Western Astrology*, 98–201 (surprisingly, Tester deals with the Latin Middle Ages only, thus almost completely ignoring the Islamic influence); recently Campion, *History of Western Astrology*, vol. II, 19–84 (like Tester, Campion only engages the Christian contexts, briefly acknowledging the “distinguished achievements of the scholars of the Islamic world” [vol. II, xvii]); von Stuckrad, *Geschichte der Astrologie*, 159–206; see also Page, *Astrology in Medieval Manuscripts*.

continuing presence of alchemy, magic, and astrology, brought into new contexts in Islamic culture.³ When in 762 the Abbasids founded their new capital in Baghdad, they built the city gates in concordance with the four directions as an *imago mundi* ("image of the world"). As it was practice already in the Roman Empire, the founding date of the city was calculated in advance.⁴ The second center of Islamic culture was Spain (Arabic *al-Andalus*), where the Umayyads had founded the Emirate of Cordoba in 755. Subsequently, Cordoba became one of the most important European cultural centers of the Middle Ages.

Between the eighth and the tenth centuries, we witness an increase of scientific activity that not only integrated and translated Hellenistic and Eastern traditions of learning but also renewed theory, practice, and technology in many ways. Therefore, it is wrong to describe Islamic science and philosophy simply as a copy of Greek thinking. One of the most fervent critics of this 'classical narrative' is George Saliba. He makes clear that even

the translation movement of early Abbāsid times, since it was generated by social conditions of the Islamic government itself, did not simply translate the classical texts, digest them and then began to create a science of its own as the classical narrative continues to tell us. What seems to have happened is that the translation and creation were taking place at the same time [...] we can discern some creative activities to have preceded the translations of the advanced text, and that those creative activities by themselves required further translations in order to lead to more creative thinking and so on. In this manner we can understand why al-Hajjāj b. Maṭar had to read Ptolemy's text very carefully and to correct it whenever he thought it was in error.⁵

³ Often, it has been argued that the Renaissance magic of a Marsilio Ficino and others is something entirely 'new'; see particularly Yates, *Giordano Bruno and the Hermetic Tradition*. Over against this simplified view, Frank Klaassen has demonstrated that Renaissance magic is built on medieval traditions; see Klaassen, "Medieval Ritual Magic in the Renaissance." Arabic tradition plays a significant role in this transmission; see particularly Marquès-Rivière, *Amulettes, talismans et pentacles*; Kieckhefer, *Magic in the Middle Ages*; Burnett (ed.), *Magic and Divination in the Middle Ages*; Fanger (ed.), *Conjuring Spirits*; Weill-Parot, *Les "images astrologiques" au moyen âge*; Bremmer & Veenstra (eds.), *Metamorphosis of Magic*.

⁴ See von Stuckrad, *Das Ringen um die Astrologie*, 149. The astrologer who calculated the date was Ma'shallāh (Latin Messallah), a Jew who had converted to Islam. With Jupiter as the ruler of the 'birth chart' of Baghdad, the Babylonian tutelary divinity Marduk merged with the highest god of Rome.

⁵ Saliba, *Islamic Science and the Making of the European Renaissance*, 66–67.

In the beginning, Persians, Indians, Jews, and Greeks were the main importers of astrological traditions, the practice of which was fostered by the Islamic rulers.⁶ Particularly the Abbasid caliphates of Baghdad provided a climate that was fruitful for the development of science and philosophy, among them Abū-Ja'far al-Mansūr, Hārūn al-Rashīd, and 'Abdallāh am-Ma'mūn. Under the regency of am-Ma'mūn (813–833) the library of Baghdad reached the height of its influence, with its most important task being the translation of all available older literature into Arabic. Am-Ma'mūn saw to it that Greek manuscripts were shipped to Baghdad from Byzantium and Cyprus. Teams of translators worked on a critical comparison of the respective documents and tried to differentiate older from newer versions, thus within two hundred years they helped to establish a concise collection of ancient sciences. Among those translations were highly important works, such as Ptolemy's *Almagest*, the major astronomical work from the second century CE.

At that time an astronomical genre was created—the so-called *zīj*—that was to become an important resource for practicing astrologers.⁷ The Persian word, in Latin versions translated as *canon*, means “table” and refers to a compilation of astronomical rules and dates that can be found in writings as early as those of Ptolemy's, and that allows astrologers to calculate in a relatively simple way the planetary positions and ascendants for specific times and places (thus, *canones* is the word not only for the tables but also for the instruction manuals that explain how to use the tables). Some of the *zījes* served as purely arithmetical or trigonometric tools, often for the calculation and conversion of calendars, others helped with the calculation of risings and settings of the sun, moon, and the planets. In many cases, they were also used for concrete tasks, for instance to calculate the hourly movement of planets, their average speed, the times of their standstills and retrograde movements, as well as prognoses of new moons and

⁶ An overview is provided in the following publications: Carmody, *Arabic Astronomical and Astrological Sciences in Latin Translations*; Lemay, *Abu Ma'shar and Latin Aristotelianism in the Twelfth Century*; Grant (ed.), *Source Book of Medieval Science*; Flint, “Transmission of Astrology”; Samsó, *Islamic Astronomy and Medieval Spain*; Grant, *Foundations of Modern Science in the Middle Ages*; Saliba, *Islamic Science and the Making of the European Renaissance*.

⁷ The astronomical relevance of this genre is explained in North, *History of Astronomy and Cosmology*, 180–183.

eclipses (which were needed for the exact calculation of the religiously important beginnings of the lunar months). Star lists—mostly derived from Ptolemy's list of 1022 stars—also served to aid in the exact determination of time and the correct use of the astrolabes that the Muslim astronomers had technically improved.

The *zīj*es were of crucial importance for casting horoscopes for two reasons: First of all, they helped to figure out correct data; astrologers consulted the tables for the place of birth or transferred the data from one place to the longitude and latitude of another place in order to calculate the ascendant and the culminating point, the so-called midheaven. Furthermore, the tables comprised methods of calculating the lifetime and the life conditions to be expected for the person in question. From the middle of the eighth century through the end of the fifteenth century, more than two hundred clearly distinct *zīj*es had been produced, about twenty of them presenting new parameters and calculations that were derived from empirical observation of the sky. Most *zīj*es followed the theory of the *Almagest*, but there were also influential tables—among them the famous *zīj* by al-Khwārizmī (c. 840)⁸—that integrated Hindu and Persian mathematical systems. Baghdad certainly was the center of this production, the first real successor of ancient Alexandria. In the east, from the middle of the tenth century Iran became the new focal point of *zīj* production, while in the west, especially in Spain, Jews played a leading role in further developing the genre. The astrologers welcomed the use of tables because now they were able to derive more or less exact dates for their horoscopes without having to master the complex methods of calculation in every detail.

Among the most important astrologers of the time, special mention must be made of Ma'shallāh, al-Kindī, Abū Ma'shar, and al-Battānī.⁹ Later Latin texts regularly call upon these four astrologers, but al-Kindī and Abū Ma'shar were undoubtedly the art's most influential representatives. Born at the end of the eighth century to an aristocratic family—his father was governor of al-Kurfān under Hārūn al-Rashīd—al-Kindī (Ya'qūb ibn Itshāq al-Kindī) laid the foundation of a philosophical defense of 'esoteric' disciplines, including astrology, magic, and other

⁸ See North, *History of Astronomy and Cosmology*, 184–185, 210–217.

⁹ Detailed references are provided in Sezgin, *Geschichte des arabischen Schrifttums* VII, 98–199; Ullmann, *Natur- und Geheimwissenschaften im Islam*, 303–358.

divinatory techniques.¹⁰ Al-Kindī became the teacher and physician of the great patron of the sciences, the caliph am-Ma'mūn. He died presumably in 866.

According to the narrative of the great chronicler an-Nadīm, the 47-year-old Abū Ma'shar (Abū Ma'shar Ja'far ben Muhammad 'Umar al-Balkhī, Latin Albumasar, 787–886) met al-Kindī and became convinced by the famous philosopher that he had to study mathematics in order to understand philosophy; so he turned from his *ḥadīth* studies to astrology¹¹ and subsequently wrote an oeuvre that in its influence on later generations of astrologers and astronomers, particularly in the Christian domain, can only be compared to that of Ptolemy.¹² Abū Ma'shar is perhaps the first astrologer who undertook a conscious amalgamation of the Ptolemaic and the Persian elements of astrological and astronomical doctrine. Born in (or near) the city of Balkh in Khurasan, a place where Jews, Nestorians, Manichaeans, Buddhists, Hindus, and Zoroastrians had settled, Abū Ma'shar became familiar with these various teachings early on. Although he presumably served the Abbasid ruler in Baghdad early in his life, he always remained close to Shiite Islam.

Abū Ma'shar left an enormous body of work that includes the following titles: the *Flores astrologiae* ("Flowers of Astrology"), a collection of brief but helpful suggestions and aphorisms that many people used as a consultation book; *De revolutionibus nativitatum* ("The Revolutions of Nativities"); two works on *Electiones* ("Elections" of right moments for action), and an influential *zīj*. Particularly responsible for his impact in the West, however, was *The Great Introduction to the Predictions from the Stars*. In 1133, this treatise was translated by John of Seville (who translated other works of Abū Ma'shar as well) as *Liber introductorius maior* ("The Great Book of Introduction"). Independently of John, Hermann of Carinthia prepared another translation

¹⁰ See Travaglia, *Magic, Causality and Intentionality*.

¹¹ Saliba argues that the "story is indicative of the relationship of astrology to the religious sciences at the time, and reflects an early attempt to attack the ancient sciences on account of their relationship to the religiously condemned discipline of astrology" (*Islamic Science and the Making of the European Renaissance*, 36). This may be part of the story, but the Shiite interest in calculating sacred history may be another reason for Abū Ma'shar's turn to astrology.

¹² His influence is stressed particularly by Richard Lemay, *Abu Ma'shar and Latin Aristotelianism*, while others—such as David Pingree, *The Thousands of Abū Ma'shar*—are more cautious about the impact and quality of his writings.

in 1140 under the title *Introductorium in astronomiam* (“Introduction to Astronomy/Astrology”). While other works focused on technical aspects, the *Liber introductorius* was relevant in a more general way, because this book presented a detailed nature-philosophical foundation and an apologia of astrology as a mathematical science. Through this book, Aristotle was introduced to the Christian West long before his specific works were actually known. For Abū Ma’shar astrology is an important natural science, including all branches of this art, even those that the opponents of astrology called *astrologia superstitiosa*, namely the interpretation of horoscopes and the making of concrete predictions.

This combination of a theoretical scientific foundation and a concrete overview of all branches of astrology made Abū Ma’shar’s text for the Latin West an ideal handbook that immediately opened up for them central areas of knowledge about nature. Hence, three hundred years after it was written, this book exerted a much more important influence in the West than it had ever had in the Islamic East.¹³

To be sure, this evaluation does not fit the impact of Abū Ma’shar’s other works in the same way. How important his contribution to the Islamic astrological discourse in fact was, becomes apparent when we look at his ‘table,’ the *zīj al-hazarāt*, because in this work he goes beyond the presentation of astronomical calculations and bases his science on a ‘Hermetic’ conceptual framework. Astrology, Abū Ma’shar tells us, was once revealed from a divine source to the wise, but people had forgotten this knowledge. His *zīj* was based on a document that according to him was hidden before the deluge in Isfahan and would now become available to the people again. Abū Ma’shar used Indian planetary parameters in his book, combining them with Ptolemy’s system; thus, instead of being antediluvian, his *zīj* reveals the progressive development of ancient astrology in Muslim cultural frameworks.

The Shiites, with their theology focusing on the Hidden Imam, embraced another theory of Abū Ma’shar, as well. Already in antiquity, astrologers had been interested in interpreting the cycles of planetary conjunctions, that is, the repeated ‘meeting’ of planets in the sky.¹⁴ In his influential work “On the Great Conjunctions” (also known

¹³ Blume, *Regenten des Himmels*, 22.

¹⁴ For ancient examples see von Stuckrad, *Das Ringen um die Astrologie*, index “Große Konjunktion.” For an interesting, though at times highly speculative, inter-

from its Arabic title as “The Book of Religions and Dynasties”),¹⁵ the Baghdad astrologer sketches a historical picture that relates the rise and fall of human institutions—religious communities and political systems—to planetary cycles. Harking back to ancient theories, Abū Ma’shar explains that the “great conjunctions” of Jupiter and Saturn, in particular with the addition of Mars,¹⁶ are responsible for world history. The periodic conjunctions of Jupiter and Saturn are divided into three main types. (a) Saturn and Jupiter form a simple conjunction approximately every twenty years, called “lesser conjunction.” (b) Due to retrograde periods of the planetary movement, there can occur a three-fold conjunction of Jupiter and Saturn, which looks like a continuous conjunction of the two planets in the sky for almost one year; given the mean rate of progress of the planets, the next conjunction will take place in the ninth sign from that in which it last occurred, i.e. it falls into the same trigon of zodiacal signs twelve times. The change from one trigon to the next one occurs after approximately 240 years and is known as the “middle conjunction.”¹⁷ (c) Since there are four zodiacal trigons—fire, earth, air, and water—it takes approximately 960 years until Saturn and Jupiter get back to their conjunction in the original sign, which is called the “great conjunction.”

In the Arabic version of “On the Great Conjunctions” Abū Ma’shar explains:

At its completion of 10 rotations there may happen conditions and changes in general in the appearance of prophethood and the shift of dynasties, religions and customs, according to what we shall describe. To take an example of this in successive times: that is, when 10 rotations were completed for Saturn in the days of Dārā bn Dārā,¹⁸ there occurred [to us] the appearance of Alexander, son of Philip, and the

pretation of the role of the Great Conjunctions in Western history see de Cesaris, *Coniunzioni Giove-Saturno e storia Giudaico-Cristiana*.

¹⁵ The authoritative edition and annotated translation is Yamamoto & Burnett (ed./trans.), *Abū Ma’shar on Historical Astrology*.

¹⁶ The inclusion of Mars in this analysis is an elaboration of earlier theories. On the development of the theory of the great conjunctions and the world-year, see Kennedy, “The Sassanian Astronomical Handbook Zij-I Shah”; Kennedy & van der Waerden, “The World-Year of the Persians”; Pingree, “Astronomy and Astrology in India and Iran.”

¹⁷ Note that this is Abū Ma’shar’s terminology, taken over by Abraham ibn Ezra and others. The three-fold conjunction (without change of trigon) is otherwise also called “great conjunction.” Cf. the table of conjunctions of Jupiter and Saturn between 200 BCE and 710 CE provided in von Stuckrad, *Das Ringen um die Astrologie*, 860–861.

¹⁸ Darius, King of the Persians.

disappearance of the Persian dynasty. When another 10 of its rotations were completed for it, Ardašīr ibn Bābikān¹⁹ appeared and he restored the dynasty of the Persians and set up their affairs. When another 10 of its rotations were completed for it, ʿĪsā bn Maryam (Upon him be peace!)²⁰ appeared with the change of the religion. When another 10 of its rotations were completed for it, Mānī appeared and he produced a religion which is between Mazdaism and Christianity. When another 10 of its rotations were completed for it, the Prophet (Upon him be peace!) brought the revealed religion of Islam.²¹

Many Shiites who were waiting for the restoration of the rightful caliphate in Persia were inspired by this doctrine because it provided the philosophical and religious explanation and—often even more important—the determination of the concrete time of this event in salvation history.

While the Shiites used Abū Maʿshar's model for calculating the return of the Mahdi, Christians and Jews later were to adopt the model themselves, applying it to the expected moment of the final judgment or the messianic time. The best-known predictions in this regard came from al-Birūnī, Ali ben Ragel (both eleventh century), and Abraham ibn Ezra (twelfth century). The latter is particularly interesting for us here, because Abraham ibn Ezra represents the Jewish adaptation of the Islamic astrological interpretation of the great conjunctions. He refers explicitly to Abū Maʿshar and other Muslim scholars, whose theories he critically discusses and applies to Jewish interests. The theory of the great conjunctions is introduced in his discussion of mundane astrology, i.e. the 'universal' world history as opposed to the lives of individuals. This is a classic topic in astrological discussion, because the problem arises how astrologers can explain that individuals sometimes are suffering a collective fate, for instance in wars, famines, or natural catastrophes. Ptolemy had already argued that this is to be explained by the fact that the horoscopes of the ruler, nation, or city are more important than the horoscopes of individuals or particulars.²²

¹⁹ Ardashir I, son of Pāpak (ruled 226–242 CE), the founder of the Sassanid dynasty.

²⁰ "Jesus, son of Mary" is the usual designation of Jesus Christ in Muslim contexts.

²¹ Ch. 8.34, quoted from Yamamoto & Burnett (ed./trans.), *Abū Maʿshar on Historical Astrology*, vol. I, 151, 153. Note that the events referred to by Abū Maʿshar do not form a chronological order; this is an example of the contingencies of 'sacred history.'

²² See Ptolemy, *Tetrabiblos* II.1.

Medieval astrologers elaborated this solution and set up a hierarchy of factors that included other mundane calculations, particularly the great conjunctions of Jupiter and Saturn. In the first of his “macro-astrological rule,” Ibn Ezra argued:

The first rule states that [the astrologer] should know to which nation the new-born (that is, the subject for whom a horoscope has been cast) belongs. Given the case that the new-born is an Israelite and that the stars’ configuration of his horoscope determine that he will become a king, it is not appropriate that [the astrologer] should pronounce the judgment that this Israelite will be crowned a king. For it has already been made clear that the great conjunction, that is the conjunction of Saturn and Jupiter, has decreed that the nation of Israelites should remain in exile. Thus this individual power cannot abrogate the more general force. Hence it is fitting that in this case [the astrologer] should pronounce the following judgment: the new-born will be close to kings, he will mingle with kings and run affairs with them, but he himself will not become a king.²³

The topic lingered on in interreligious debate. Around 1470 it was Isaac Abarbanel who caused a sensation with his prediction—in fact, another example of creative historiography—that the return of the great trigon into the sign of Pisces signified the arrival of the messiah and the beginning of the Jewish salvation period. Abarbanel made use of Bar Hiyya’s version of this theory, which stated that the great conjunction of Jupiter and Saturn in Pisces saw the revelation of the Torah; their seventh great conjunction in Virgo represented the rise and spread of Christianity, while the second meeting of these planets in Pisces in the year 1464 would lead to the nations’ final downfall and the beginning of Israel’s deliverance.²⁴

A little later, the great conjunction of the year 1483/4 led to a heated discussion among European scholars, a discussion that was related, among other issues, to the birth chart of Martin Luther; the reformer

²³ Abraham ibn Ezra, *Sefer ha-Moladot*, quoted from Sela, *Abraham ibn Ezra and the Rise of Medieval Hebrew Science*, 347 (see also the Hebrew text provided there); cf. also Abraham ibn Ezra’s *Sefer ha-Olam* (“Book of the World”), discussed by Sela, *ibid.*, 166–167. Sela concludes that “it is easy to understand why and how these astrological techniques were so extensively employed by medieval astrologers to give a comprehensive explanation of the fluctuations in human history as well as prognostications of future collective events” (p. 168). On the topic see further Rodrigues-Arribas, “Historical Horoscopes of Israel.” On Jewish astral magic in the Middle Ages see Schwartz, “La magie astrale”; Schwartz, *Studies on Astral Magic*.

²⁴ See Lawee, *Isaac Abarbanel’s Stance Toward Tradition*, 129–130.

later even faked his year of birth in order to let it correspond to the great conjunction.²⁵ Astrology is interreligious and open to a great variety of rhetorical charging.

In close contact with the eastern centers of the Islamic world, between the eighth and the fifteenth centuries the Spanish caliphates—in addition to the Staufer rule in Italy that I do not have the space to address here²⁶—formed the most important focal points of science and philosophy. Without them, the flourishing of astrology in the early modern period would have been impossible. In the course of time the research in al-Andalus outmatched the schools of Baghdad, and Spain became the new intellectual center of Islam. Spain had a scientific tradition already before the Muslim conquest—due to the influence of Isidore of Seville whose encyclopedic work I will discuss later—but astronomy in those days was mainly interested in simple questions such as the synchronization of calendars or (later on) determining the *qibla*, that is, the direction of Mecca, toward which Muslims face to pray. Only in the tenth century can a flourishing of research be seen. During the caliphate of Abd al-Rachman III (912–961) the emirate of Cordoba began to surpass the Abbasid caliphate in scientific performance. The emir sent agents to Baghdad, Damascus, and Cairo to get hold of all available publications, and in the second half of the tenth century schools for mathematics, astronomy, and other arts were founded that systematized, commented, and extended the material from the East. The astronomer al-Majriti (died c. 1007) who worked in Cordoba, transferred al-Khwārismi's table to the meridian of Cordoba and synchronized the Islamic calendar that began with the Hijra.²⁷ Al-Majriti educated a whole group of famous astronomers, and soon other places on the Spanish peninsula, among them Seville, Valencia, Saragossa, and Toledo, followed the example of Cordoba.

From the beginning Spain had been characterized by a vivid exchange between religious traditions, fostered not only by the Muslim rulers. Jews and converts had a key position in these processes, since their multilingualism made them first-class translators. The

²⁵ On the overall discussion see Ernst, "From the Watery Trigon to the Fiery Trigon"; Barnes, *Prophecy and Gnosis*, 141–181; Smoller, *History, Prophecy, and the Stars*; Geneva, *Astrology and the Seventeenth-Century Mind*, 118–140; Harkness, *John Dee's Conversations with Angels*, 69–71; von Stuckrad, *Geschichte der Astrologie*, 232–241, 244–249.

²⁶ See von Stuckrad, *Geschichte der Astrologie*, 196–199.

²⁷ North, *History of Astronomy and Cosmology*, 184–185.

borders between religions—we should not forget that ‘conversions,’ in whichever direction they may occur, are never complete—were more fluent in those days than during other periods, and all parties shared a common cultural milieu that radiated into the Latin north even before the translation endeavors actually started. This does not mean, of course, that the situation was a happy multiculturalism without any tension, quite the contrary: as in many other cases discussed in this book, religious identities were formed through polemical differentiation. The status of Jews, for instance, was extremely precarious. But those periods wherein religious tolerance was practiced—such as under Alfonso X of Castile—were culturally very productive. We thus find a rich astrological discourse in Andalusia that involved reputed followers and critics of astrology. One of them was Ali ben Ragel.

Ali ben Ragel (‘Ali ibn Abīr-Rijāl, Latin Abenragel Haly, 1016–1062) is one of the astrologers who were most received in the high Middle Ages. Some scholars assume that he had enjoyed an astrological education in Baghdad, but that is not certain. What we know is that he was employed as notary and astrologer at the court of the Zirid al-Mu‘izz ibn Bādīs in Tunis. His major work is the “Great Book about the Judgments from the Stars,” consisting of eight parts, in which the author systematically compiled the whole knowledge of his time. Ali ben Ragel refers explicitly to old masters such as ‘Hermes,’ Dorotheus, Ptolemy, Ma’shallāh, and al-Kindī, and he discusses the advantages and disadvantages of their respective doctrines. The work became known in Europe through the translation into Old Castilian (1254), prepared by Yehuda Moshe, the personal physician of King Alfonso X, on the latter’s request. Unfortunately, only the first five books of this translation are extant. Yehuda Moshe’s version was the basis for subsequent Latin translations, printed for the first time as *Praeclarissimus liber completus in judiciis astrorum* at Erhard Ratdolt in Venice (1485). Renaissance astrologers made ample use of it, which can be seen from the fact that the book was reprinted six times between 1503 and 1571. In those days, Ali ben Ragel was celebrated as *summus astrologus* (“highest astrologer”) or even as *Ptolemaeus alter* (“second Ptolemy”). “It is a strange feeling to hold in one’s hands a book that was written by a Muslim on request of a Christian king, translated by a Jew.”²⁸

²⁸ Brand, *Lehrbuch der klassischen Astrologie*, 10.